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From the editor-in-chief

This is an anxious time for parents and their offspring trying to gain admission in the college of their choice. The economic crisis and its impact on jobs will add to the anxiety and make the selection of an educational institution even more critical. In today's competitive environment, the scramble for college seats has become an annual ritual which separates the best from the rest as students gravitate to the country's best colleges. That begs the question: which are the best colleges? At the end of the day, it's really a mix of perception, reputation and performance but even that straddles a very fine line. To categorise the best colleges in the country, we at INDIA TODAY annually commission a reputable market research company to conduct a comprehensive survey of academic excellence. Now in its 13th year, the INDIA TODAY survey is considered the gold standard in college rankings. Over the years we have fine-tuned the ranking process.

The process began late last year when research was conducted to generate the list of colleges for the survey across 12 major cities based on perception as well as various secondary data sources. This exercise resulted in a comprehensive list of more than 1,500 colleges. To calculate the final score, nearly 1,000 experts at the level of principals, heads of department and deans were interviewed for the various stages and streams. After a comprehensive list of each of the streams was compiled, the next step was to capture the 'awareness level' of various institutes, also from experts. These were based on five vital parameters—Reputation of Colleges, Quality of Academic Inputs, Student Care, Infrastructure and Job Prospects. The most important parameter got the maximum weight. To eliminate bias, the experts were not allowed to rate their own colleges.

Next, we asked the experts to rate the colleges on a national perspective. Finally, to determine the overall ranking, colleges that figured in the Top 50 in Arts, Science and Commerce streams and Top 25 in Engineering, Medicine and Law were contacted for factual data. Colleges that did not provide the data were eliminated from the final ranking process. All factual information related to a college was rescaled and then aggregated to get an overall factual score. To calculate the final overall score, a 70:30 weightage was then assigned to perceptual and factual scores respectively. The methodology of ranking, based on both perceptual and factual data, we believe provides a comprehensive picture of each college rated. The 2009 survey reveals that while there was a minor reshuffling of ranks among the toppers of last year, big shifts happened among the so-called middle rankers, indicating that performance pays.

We live in an age where knowledge is power as well as a major national asset. As the late US President John F. Kennedy once said: "Let us think of education as the means of developing our greatest abilities, because in each of us there is a private hope and dream which, fulfilled, can be translated into benefit for everyone and greater strength for our nation." There is no better incentive for us to conduct this annual exercise.

(Aroon Purie)



OUR JUNE
2008 COVER